

The Claremont City Council held a meeting on Thursday, September 21, 2017, in the Council Chambers of City Hall.

The meeting was called to order by Mayor Lovett at 6:30 p.m.

Members of the Council present were:

Ward I Councilor Carolyn Towle
Ward II Councilor Scott Pope
At-Large Councilor Keith Raymond
Assistant Mayor Allen Damren
Mayor Charlene Lovett
Ward III Councilor Nicholas Koloski
At-Large Councilor John Simonds

Absent:

At-Large Councilor Bruce Temple

Mayor Lovett said there is a meeting at the Trinity Episcopal Church at 7 p.m. to discuss where we go from here and what actions are to be taken so what happened to Quincy doesn't happen again. She said she's been asked to say a few words and was asked if Councilors would also go. Council will break at 7 p.m. and then come back to continue.

CITIZEN'S FORUM

Bernie Folta, Ward 3, reminded everyone this is an election year, Tuesday, November 7th. The entire Council is up for election. The filing period is September 20 to September 29. He said the two candidates that are vying for the vacant seat tonight intend to file for the November election. He hopes people step forward and run for Council.

NEW BUSINESS

Interview and Selection of Candidate to Fill Vacant At-Large Councilor Seat

- Candidates will alternate answering each question first
- Candidates make an Opening Statement

Abigail Kier said she moved to Claremont a little over three years ago. She ran for Council two years ago. She has served on the Zoning Board of Adjustment (ZBA), Master Plan Steering Committee, Policy Committee and Historic District Commission (HDC). She wants to be a part of an inclusive open-minded Council. She enjoys living here.

David Pacetti said he is a lifelong resident and that sitting on the Council would be an opportunity to help the community. He was on the JSL (Junior Sports League) Board for 15 years; he was vice chair. He has donated funds to the City. His objective is to serve the community the best way he can. He hopes his experience dealing with the City will be a benefit to the Council.

- Questions (**these will not be made public until they are read at the interview**)
 - o 1. How have you personally invested yourself in Claremont?

Ms. Towle read the question and then asked the candidates to go more in depth about what improvements they would suggest.

Mr. Pacetti said he served with the JSL and has been involved with the community for a number of years. He would like to restore the JSL so the kids have place to go. He would like to get more things that would involve kids. Kids need some place to go.

Ms. Kier said she feels there is a lot of room for improvement in a lot of areas, for example, community involvement. She said regarding the Master Plan, it is interesting to see how the City has progressed and what has been achieved. Ordinance updates are supposed to be done every 5 years, but that is not done. Economic development-bringing in families, highlight positives, need infrastructure to support those families.

- o 2. What motivates you to serve as a City Councilor?

Mr. Pope read the question.

Mayor Lovett felt that had already been covered. Councilors agreed.

- o 3. What do you hope to accomplish in the next three months if you are chosen as a Councilor?

Mr. Pope read the question.

Ms. Kier said that her job is mostly process improvement. Her hope would be to bring in some new and innovative ideas. She hopes to be able to contribute to things that are already in process. As part of a younger generation, she may bring a different point of view to the Council.

Mr. Pacetti said that he has worked in manufacturing which involves process improvement and he hopes to focus on things that are not working to the fullest extent. New laws coming from the state (i.e. new tax break codes) need to be thoroughly developed to see if they could benefit Claremont. He has contacts that may help to bring manufacturing businesses to Claremont. The City needs to bring in housing and industry to promote growth.

- o 4. What is there about Claremont that makes you proud to live here?

Mr. Simonds read the question.

Mr. Pacetti said community. The people in the City are fabulous. If something happens, everyone comes together as a community.

Ms. Kier echoed community as well. She has lived in seven different places and Claremont is the most enjoyable place to live. Everyone is so accommodating. There are so many resources here. She enjoys how open the community is. It is easy to come into City offices to get answers. She enjoys how people band together.

Because one question had been eliminated, Councilors were asked if they had something else to ask. Mr. Raymond asked the following question.

- o 5. What do you see as downfalls or obstacles that might be in the way of you, as a City Councilor, getting the job done?

Ms. Kier said an obstacle would be each other. It is very hard to get nine people to totally agree on issues. We need everyone to be open-minded and listen to other's feedback.

Mr. Pacetti said time management. It's hard to get a nine-person Council to agree. It's important to work together to get things done in a timely manner.

- Candidates make a Closing Statement

Mr. Pacetti said he will do his very best to help the Council with the knowledge he has to get processes done and to get information needed.

Ms. Kier said she would be happy to help serve; to bring energy, different thoughts and background to decisions. She is happy to be a part of Claremont.

- Council deliberates and then votes

Mr. Simonds said he enjoyed hearing from both candidates. He gave some background regarding his appointment to the Council. He was told it is good to see the City government from the inside out instead of just outside in. It is a tough choice. His vote will be for Ms. Kier. He has worked with her on the Policy Committee. She is dedicated to the City.

Mr. Koloski said he is happy both candidates will put their names on the ballot to run for Council in November. He has seen Ms. Kier in action on the boards and committees she sits on. He hasn't seen Mr. Pacetti, so for that reason, he would cast his vote for Ms. Kier. He is able to follow the logic she brings to the process. He looks forward to Mr. Pacetti running for Council.

Mr. Raymond said he has seen Ms. Kier's work on the ZBA; she is very professional. He thanked Mr. Pacetti for applying. His vote will be for Ms. Kier.

Mr. Pope said both are extremely qualified. He has seen both in action – Ms. Kier on boards and Mr. Pacetti in manufacturing. Both have a lot of good ideas. He talked about a workforce meeting this afternoon and then said his vote will be for Mr. Pacetti.

Ms. Towle said she appreciated what both had said. She is thrilled both put in applications for Council. She has enjoyed her years on the Council. She has worked with Ms. Kier. She convinced Ms. Kier to join the ZBA. She thanked Mr. Pacetti. She said her vote would go to Ms. Kier.

Mr. Damren said he knows Ms. Kier, but does not know Mr. Pacetti. Both bring different mindsets to issues faced by the Council and that would be refreshing. He wished them both well and success with the November election. He said he will vote for Ms. Kier as he feels she'll bring a fresh approach to the Council.

Mayor Lovett said she echoes how much she appreciates both being willing to serve the community. She said she hopes the Council gets the opportunity to work with both in January, but for the next three months, her vote would be for Ms. Kier.

Roll call vote: Votes for Abigail Kier: Ms. Towle, Mr. Raymond, Mr. Damren, Mr. Koloski, Mr. Simonds and Mayor Lovett. Vote for David Pacetti: Mr. Pope. Abigail Kier was selected to fill the vacant At-Large Councilor seat.

- Selected candidate will be sworn in by Gwen Melcher

Swearing In of At-Large Councilor

City Clerk Gwen Melcher swore in Abigail Kier to the vacant At-Large Council seat.

At 7:21 p.m. Ms. Kier joined the rest of the Council at the table.

CONSULTATION WITH LEGAL COUNSEL

None

Mayor Lovett said September 27 regular Council meeting and September 28 joint Council/School Board meeting. Tuesday, CSB Community Center, 6:30 p.m.-8 p.m., public forum for volunteer station hosts at the Amtrak station. To meet the goal of becoming a medium station, there has to be 14 people off and on per day.

Mayor Lovett said former Assistant Mayor Victor Bergeron was leading the Policy Committee. She said Mr. Pope is on the Policy Committee and Ms. Kier was a citizen on the Policy Committee.

Mr. Pope said the Policy Committee will meet and elect a chair. Ms. Kier will now fill a Council seat and the citizen seat will be open. That seat needs to be advertised.

Mayor Lovett asked if the Policy Committee had started on the lead policy. Mr. Pope said not yet.

Mayor Lovett said the Committee will be getting a draft of a fund balance policy.

Mr. Pope said there are now two Councilors on the Historic District Commission.

Mr. Koloski said a Councilor is needed to fill the regular City Councilor seat on the Planning Board. Mr. Damren said he can fill the Planning Board seat. Mayor Lovett said he will apply just as Assistant Mayor Bergeron had done.

ADJOURNMENT

At 7:28 p.m., a motion was made by Mr. Damren and seconded by Ms. Towle to adjourn.

Voice vote: motion carried 8-0.

Respectfully Submitted,

Dorée M. Russell
Clerk to the Council